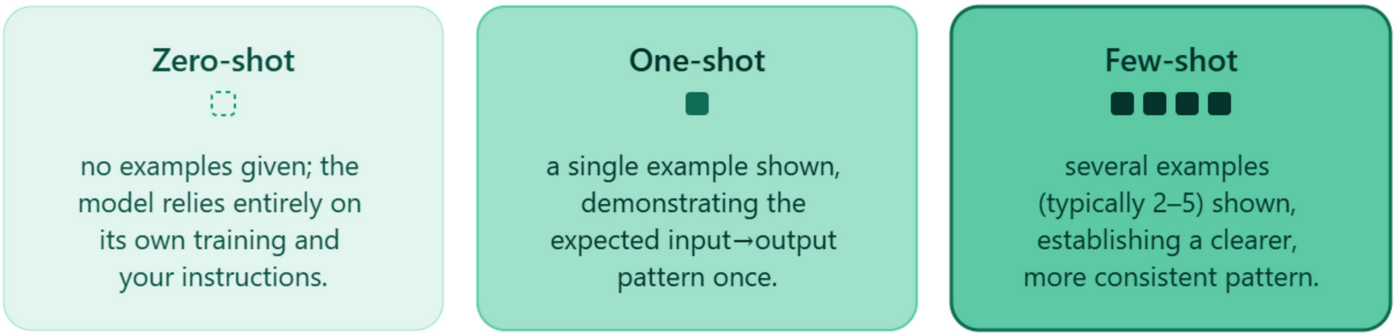
Zero-Shot, One-Shot, and Few-Shot: When to Use Each

Introduction

Zero-shot, one-shot, and few-shot are three ways of asking a model to do the same task, differing only in how many examples you give it first. This reading puts them side by side so you can decide, before you write a prompt, which one actually fits the task in front of you.

The three approaches



Seeing the difference in practice

Zero-shot

```
Classify the sentiment of this review: "The battery died in two days."
```

One-shot

```
Review: "Fast shipping, loved it!" → Positive

Review: "The battery died in two days." → ?
```

Few-shot

```
Review: "Fast shipping, loved it!" → Positive

Review: "Arrived broken, no response from support." → Negative

Review: "It's fine, does what it says." → Neutral

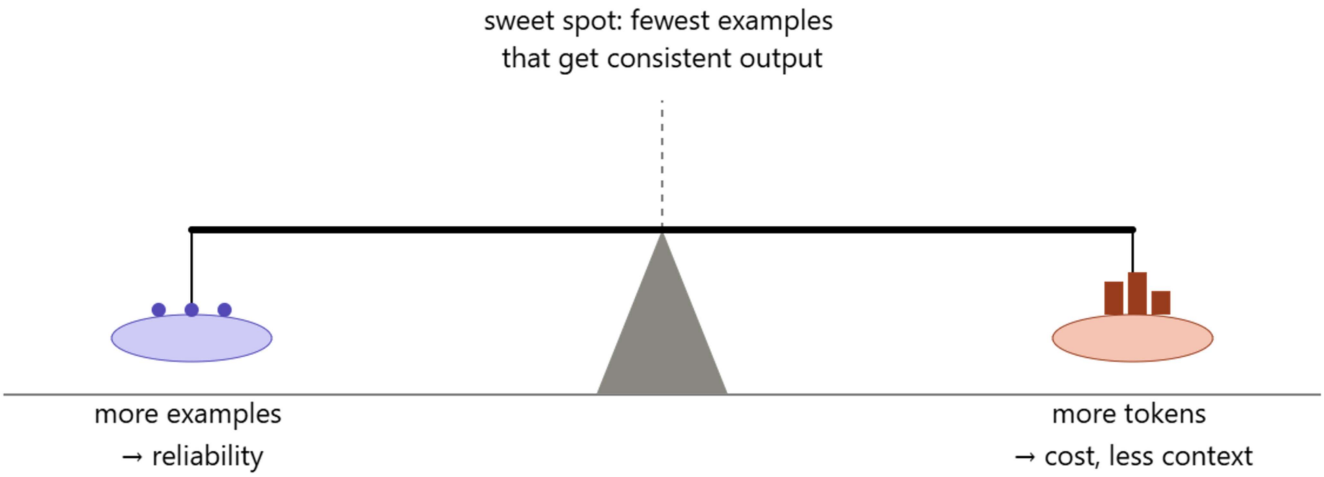
Review: "The battery died in two days." → ?
```

Same task, same final question — but each version gives the model a different amount of pattern to anchor to before it answers.

When to reach for each one

Use this...	When...
Zero-shot	The task is common/well-known, or you want the model's unbiased default behavior
One-shot	The task has a specific format or style you need demonstrated, but the pattern is simple
Few-shot	The task is nuanced, has edge cases, or a single example could be misread as a coincidence

The trade-off to keep in mind



A quick decision check

- Is this a well-known task the model likely already "knows" how to do? **try zero-shot first.**
- Did zero-shot get the format or tone wrong? **add one example.**
- Is the model still inconsistent, or does the task have tricky edge cases? **move to few-shot.**

Summary

Zero-shot

fastest, cheapest, best for tasks the model already handles well.

One-shot

fixes format/style drift with minimal added cost.

Few-shot

best for nuance and consistency, at the cost of prompt length.

Rule of thumb

start with zero-shot, add examples only when the output tells you it's needed.